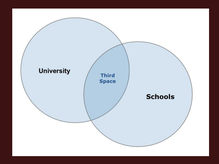


Teacher Educator In-Between: A Self Study

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Abstract

This poster presents the initial findings from an on-going self-study that examines the development of a school-university liaison role in the first year of a partnership between a turnaround, urban secondary school and the teacher education program at a large university. Responding to Zeichner's call for the development of a 'third space' in teacher education, this study suggests that in the early stages of a partnership, teacher education lives within a borderlands (Anzaldua, 1987) situation, where boundaries and roles are in flux, trust is unsteady, and information sometimes withheld. As relationships grow between the school and the university, there lies potential for the traditional boundaries delineating the work of teacher education to fade. Yet, as the process of building a partnership ensues, those of us who work and live within this third space, must navigate shifting and uncertain terrain.

Developing a 'Third Space' in teacher education

Zeichner (2010): "Teacher education programs should inhabit a **third space** between academic and practical worlds."

Zeichner's reference to Bhabha's concept of third space suggests a shared element of teacher education, where the previous binary between the university and schools disappears, and in its place, joint positions, shared authority, and collective learning takes place for teachers, academics and teacher candidates alike.

Soja argues that **third spaces** offer new opportunities, creative combinations, realignment, openness and restructuring.

While in transition towards a Professional Development School (PDS), it becomes increasingly difficult to delineate between previously separate and, in many ways, distinct roles such as:

- *Teacher and teacher candidate;*
- *Teacher educator and cooperating teacher;*
- *Teacher and researcher;*
- *Insider and outsider.*

University	Work that takes place in between	School
Faculty Staff Supervisors Coordinators Graduate Assistants Researchers CEHD students Dean's office Alumns	• Match-making • Critical incidents • Communication/ translation • Temperature taking • Build trust/confidence • Nurture relationships • Evaluation/ Judging of TCs, U program, CTs, Schools • Solve problems • Positioning • Co-teaching support • TPA support/info • Mentoring/ professional support • Coaching • Listening • Recruiting	Teachers Principal Staff Union Reps District Leads P-12 students Parents

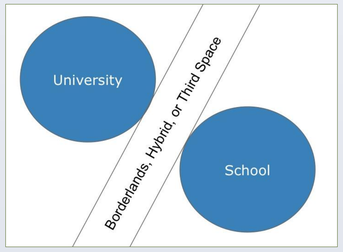
Conceptual Framework, Context, and Methods of Study

Conceptual Framework

Borderlands

Borders are set up to define the places that are safe and unsafe, to distinguish us from them. A border is a dividing line, a narrow strip along a steep edge. A borderland is a vague and undetermined place created by the emotional residue of an unnatural boundary. It is in a constant state of transition. Anzaldua, p. 25

Borderlands, as a conceptual framework, captures a context where boundaries between university- and school-based teacher education are in flux.



Context

- Turnaround urban secondary school
- Initial co-teaching pilot
- Year 1 of partnership with University
- Only secondary cluster in the district, as University partner
- 90% students of color, 90% students who qualify as eligible for free- and reduced-lunch.

Self Study

My Role

- Part time teacher on special assignment (T.O.S.A.), situated at turnaround high school
- University graduate assistant
- Position at school where I formerly taught
- No formal job description for T.O.S.A. position
- Work has included:

research, research coordination, mentoring/ induction/ coaching, counseling, trouble-shooting, consulting, methods instruction, liaison work between university and school, TC coordination and support, CT coordination and support, co-teaching training, observation of struggling TCs, PLC leadership, instructional leadership team.

Insider/ Outsider

I am, in part, a member of the school community and a colleague, while simultaneously I am a member of the university and teacher education. My work history has earned me some degree of credibility within the school and with the teachers. Because they knew me as a teacher first, they trust that I understand the context in which they live as teachers. They have seen me struggle and succeed with the same students and under the same conditions. Yet at the same time, I represent the university and serve as a conduit to the teacher education programs, their decisions, policies and protocols. In these borderlands, we are trying to define ourselves and our roles in ways that do not reinforce an us-them binary, as such a dualism should no longer apply.

Data collection:

Analytic/ reflexive memos (n=38) as field texts.

Findings

Positioning

Themes of "insider/ outsider" were present in the data.

- *Data suggests that the role lives in a third space between classroom teacher and administration, between "school person" and "university person". My time, office, and presence are all dually located, split between school and the university. Data shows that I am positioned by colleagues at the university and at school as an insider ("Us") at times and positioned as an outsider ("Them") at others. Additionally, there are times when I choose to position myself as a university person or as a classroom teacher. How I am positioned, whether by my own choosing or by others, impacts the information shared with me, my ability to build trust, and the authority I carry in a given situation.*

Trust, Relationships and Access to Information:

Mentor and colleague

- *My past work at the school and at the university enables me to establish trust through mentoring and collegial roles. Defining my work through these lenses contributes to my ability to support cooperating teachers, teacher candidates and new teachers who have graduated from the university programs.*

Earning / losing trust

- *Data showed that over the course of the first year in the position, trust with colleagues from the school and/ or from the university proved inconsistent. Extended time at the school distanced me from relationships with university colleagues and impacted their trust and, subsequently, their willingness to share information with me.*

Asked to choose sides

- *When challenging situations with cooperating teachers or teacher candidates presented themselves, I was pressed by university and school colleagues to "choose a side" and align myself with the university or the school. Consequently, the 'side' I choose furthered or detracted from the relationships and trust established with university or school colleagues.*

Communication vs. Translation

Different perspectives and different 'truths'.

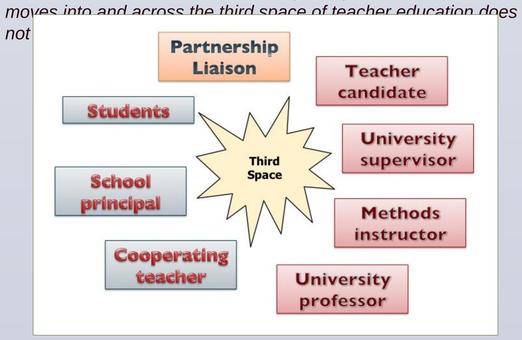
- *Because of the situated and culturally-specific nature of the work, cooperating teachers, teacher candidates, university supervisors, and university professors each have their own interpretation of truth and reality. When conflict arises within a placement, the teacher educator in-between hears multiple versions of the truth, some contradictory.*

Communication/ translation of these perspectives is situated, culturally specific.

- *Communication within borderlands between university supervisors and site-based cooperating teachers is grounded in these culturally-specific and situated lenses. Thus events, conflicts and misunderstandings are interpreted and evaluated through different frames and values.*

Even correct translations aren't fully understood.

- *As partnership liaison, translating between university and school educators, between cultures of theory and practice, as the work moves into and across the third space of teacher education does not*



Implications

Every school needs a teacher educator in-between.

Supports and strengthens **grounding** of **teacher education** practice in **school realities.**

- *The role facilitates communication of the situational circumstances and context of the specific site.*
- *The teacher educator in-between supports and strengthens the ability to ground teacher education in the realities, intensity, and urgency of the work.*

Role definition is critical.

- *The work of teacher education that takes place between the school and the university is complex and multifaceted.*
- *Liaison work can merge with placement responsibilities, cooperating teacher-teacher candidate pairing, supervision of student teaching, administration, instructional leadership, mentoring, and assessment.*

Schools need **commitment** and **sustainability.**

- *So much of the work involves relationship building and the development of trust in order to bridge the borderlands between university and schools. Liaisons must remain in the role for extended periods in order to build those relationships and trust.*

The aim should be to move toward a truly **hybrid/ third space**, where the work is **shared, co-owned,** and where both **practical** and **theoretical knowledge** is valued.

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